FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Numbers and statistics may seem a coy method to access the subject of sexuality, but broad chunks of data can give us vital clues to how society is evolving. The 18th edition of the India Today Sex Survey, the first after a Covid-enforced hiatus of four years, offers us a lens into the state of post-pandemic India in its most intimate realm. The news is not all good. A kind of generalised dissatisfaction is the overwhelming sense one gets from the 3,032 respondents who filled up the questionnaire prepared by poll agency MDRA. Deeper patterns reinforce that conclusion. We are calling it 'The Pleasure Gap'. If we treat this as a barometer of how happy and balanced we are at the core, it means our indices are in the red.

Sex is a primal need, like air, water and food, so its scarcity is a matter of concern for both individual and collective well-being. Are we living through an undeclared crisis? Counter-intuitive though it may seem, the numbers would suggest so. Take one broad-brush statistic from the survey: over 57 per cent say they "need more sex" than they get. And those who say they are "not at all happy" with their sex life have increased from 5.5 per cent in 2018 to 19 per cent. But this is not just a question of quantity. As we travel deeper into the statistical map, we see frustration is not a mere function of the absence of sex. It's woven into the very tapestry of human interactions. The question of quality is creeping in.



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Some trends apply across the board and capture us as a people caught in transition—half-liberated, half-inhibited. Demonstrating the first part, respondents expectedly reveal more permissive attitudes on certain aspects. Those who have had multiple partners went up from 5 per cent in 2017 to 19 per cent in 2023; those who say yes to one-night stands from 35 per cent to 54 per cent; and teenage sex from 24 per cent in 2018 to 35 per cent in 2023. But this cohabits with conservatism, prudishness and plain awkwardness on aspects like sexual positions or foreplay. Or that favourite of the past that lingers: virginity is still important for 52.2 per cent.

That last one leads us to a vital truth. The Pleasure Gap has a direct correlation with that other one: the Gender Gap. The systemic creation of unfulfilled wants applies more to women. Consider the bald facts. Getting mid-way into the third decade of the 21st century, 45.2 per cent of women still admit to faking orgasms. The awareness of female erogenous zones is poor among both men and women. These statistics may not have been drastically different in more repressed epochs, but that is precisely what is surprising.

Combine these with the varying responses to technology or artefacts, and the trend is revealing. More women than men feel virtual sex can improve the quality of their sex lives. Also, more of them use dating apps to find sexual partners and feel sex gadgets could replace intimacy with a partner and are willing to spend more on them. Any means to expand the ambit of pleasure is good, but this want stems from non-fulfilment in real-life relationships.

There are other pointers to what Amrita Narayanan, in her column, calls "patriarchal anxiety". Old feudal attitudes that value virginity have a new-age counterpart. Sex toys remain a taboo, and perhaps women tend to internalise the shame over it more. Over 54 per cent of men say they wouldn't date a woman who uses sex toys. Around 57 per cent of women reciprocate too. And more women (63.4 per cent) would *not* admit to using one to their friends than those who would (22.1 per cent). More men than women feel a woman using sex toys is worse than a man using them (41.9 per cent against 36.6 per cent). Also, as Narayanan points out, both sides may actually be more comfortable discussing this with the opinion pollster than with each other! "Women are more reluctant to discuss their sexual needs.... Is this reticence a function of women's shyness in sexual matters?" she asks, and proceeds to embed her answer in the phenomenon of the self-absorbed male. She feels women still tend to accept the centrality of men and the whole drama of sex being written around their perspective, while they "identify more with being pleasing objects". This internalised denial extends to homosexuality: 40 per cent of those who identify as gays have never had gay sex.

All this is against the larger contradiction that Leeza Mangaldas, India's foremost sex-positive content creator, points to in her column. Contemporary life creates the illusion of society being awash with a surfeit of sex. A variety of stimuli for pleasure seems to permeate the air: hypersexualised pop culture images, the arrival of sex toys on online shelves, digital access via the profusion of digital apps or modern inventions like phone sex, and online porn that is even easier to reach than the friendly neighbourhood store. But there is a mismatch between impression and reality. While technology is rapidly changing all aspects of our lives, social mores are slower to change, creating an imbalance. The survey numbers capture this gulf between what surrounds us as a loose ambient culture and our hesitant immersion in it. So it's well to be aware that a gap exists between desire and fulfilment and try and understand why.

At one level, strong residues from an older culture of shame continue to infect our present amidst the bustling super-bazaars of desire. On another, we see the present creating its own distortions. As Mangaldas writes, "Learning about sex from mainstream internet porn is like learning how to drive by watching *The Fast and the Furious*." Sex education exists mainly as a joke in the country, and this is the exact age when it is most needed. Conversations about sexuality need to be more open at the social level, self-affirming at the individual level and, most importantly, reciprocal between partners. Hope this special issue helps open the curtains, and lets in some light.



(Aroon Purie)